

Architectural styles

CONTEMPORARY

There is no single style that defines contemporary architecture. Architects working today draw from a range of sources, ideas, influences, and technologies to create buildings that can be iconic or particular to their settings.

Contemporary architecture is defined by its plurality, with architects around the world working at a variety of scales, in a diversity of styles and formal modes, and utilizing a range of building materials. Computer-aided design and advanced engineering techniques offer architects today an extraordinary freedom to produce almost any conceivable shape—client and budget permitting. At the same time, many architects resist the temptations of form-making in favor of developing designs that emerge from an understanding of buildings' settings and contexts in terms of form, scale, or materials.

What connects the diversity of approaches is an awareness of a building's environmental footprint. Construction entails actually altering the physical environment and has significant environmental impacts on both a local and a global scale. Concrete, which is a key material of nearly every building, is responsible for around 8 percent of global CO₂ emissions. As a result, many contemporary buildings incorporate ecological features, such as solar panels, water recycling systems, and even passive ventilation systems to reduce the use of air conditioning. On a more fundamental level, sophisticated building modeling software allows a building's environmental performance to be measured—and subsequently improved—during the design phase.

exterior steel frame supports building against lateral forces, such as seismic activity

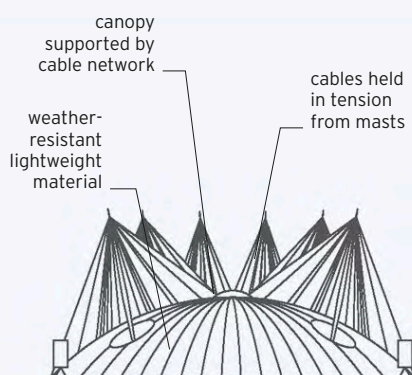
glass curtain wall allows natural light to filter inside

complex polygonal form

ceiling of 10th-floor reading room reaches maximum height of 40 ft (12 m)

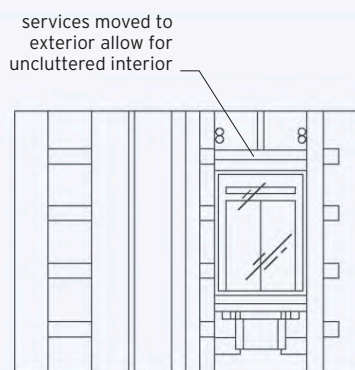
four-story Books Spiral houses main collection on continuous, uninterrupted route upward

CONTEMPORARY COMPLEXITIES



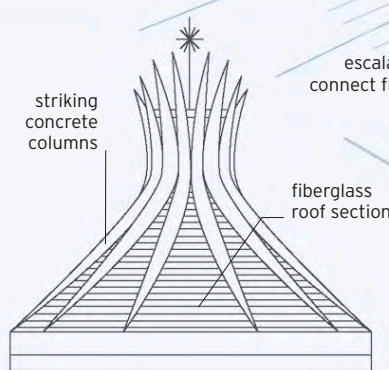
▲ TENT ROOFS

Coming to the fore in the 1960s and 1970s, tent roofs or tensile structures allow the spanning of large spaces with a minimal amount of materials and lower budgets.



▲ EXTERIOR ELEVATORS

The 1980s High-Tech movement aimed to create completely flexible internal spaces by moving structures, services, and sometimes circulation spaces to a building's exterior.



▲ COMPLEX GEOMETRIES

Complex geometrical structures, such as the hyperboloid above, are a notable trend in contemporary architecture, utilized for their powerful formal presence and structural advantages.

escalators connect floors

platform hangs over street below

side of building extends along an entire city block

▲ SEATTLE CENTRAL LIBRARY

Opened in 2004, the 11-story building from architects Rem Koolhaas and Joshua Ramus consists of five interior platforms that appear to be unsupported. Encased in a curtain wall of steel and energy-efficient glass, the geometric shape provides adaptable space for the library's collection to grow and change.